in Southeast Asia to counter China (a development that had Thornton commenting, “This sounds like what we were trying to do a decade ago”).[116] Then, in August, Desai accepted an invitation from Brezhnev.[117]

But Desai also made it clear that the Soviet relationship would not veto other relationships. He publicly stated that he would not think about every foreign policy move in terms of whether it might anger others.[118] Thus the prime minister indicated his willingness to travel to the US to meet with Carter.[119] Along with inviting the US chief of naval operations, India also sought greater naval cooperation.[120] On a visit to the US, Vajpayee told the *New York Times* that Delhi would maintain its friendship with Moscow, but would avoid the “special relationship” that Gandhi had developed—she, he said, “committed the blunder of making India too much dependent” on the Soviet Union. Thus India looked forward to a “new chapter” with the US.[121]

The China Rapprochements

Even as Washington watched Delhi’s interactions with Moscow, it also kept a close eye on Sino-Indian relations. When Gandhi had been in office, she told Percy that progress in India’s relationship with China was a “major breakthrough”—one that she had not allowed Moscow to veto.[122] Nonetheless, Beijing perceived her government as pro-Soviet and, as NSC China hand Michael Armacost had noted, had “reacted favorably” to her defeat.[123] When Desai came to office another NSC China hand, Michel Oksenberg, had asked the Indian political counselor about the new government’s likely approach to China. Rao, the Indian official, thought the Desai government’s potentially tougher stance toward Bangladesh and Pakistan might complicate its ability to improve relations with China.[124]

This was not what the Carter administration had wanted to hear. Further steps toward Sino-Indian reconciliation could make its life simpler. It would serve to limit Soviet influence in India. It would also make it easier to work with Beijing on regional issues and, as Armacost put it, “pursue our parallel interests” in a “mildly coordinated fashion.”[125]

The Desai government, contrary to Rao’s expectation, was interested in improving relations with all of India’s neighbors. At a conference of Indian heads of mission in East and Southeast Asia, Desai emphasized that positive relationships with India’s neighbors could be a “great asset” for India.[126] Indian commentators felt a better China relationship could help